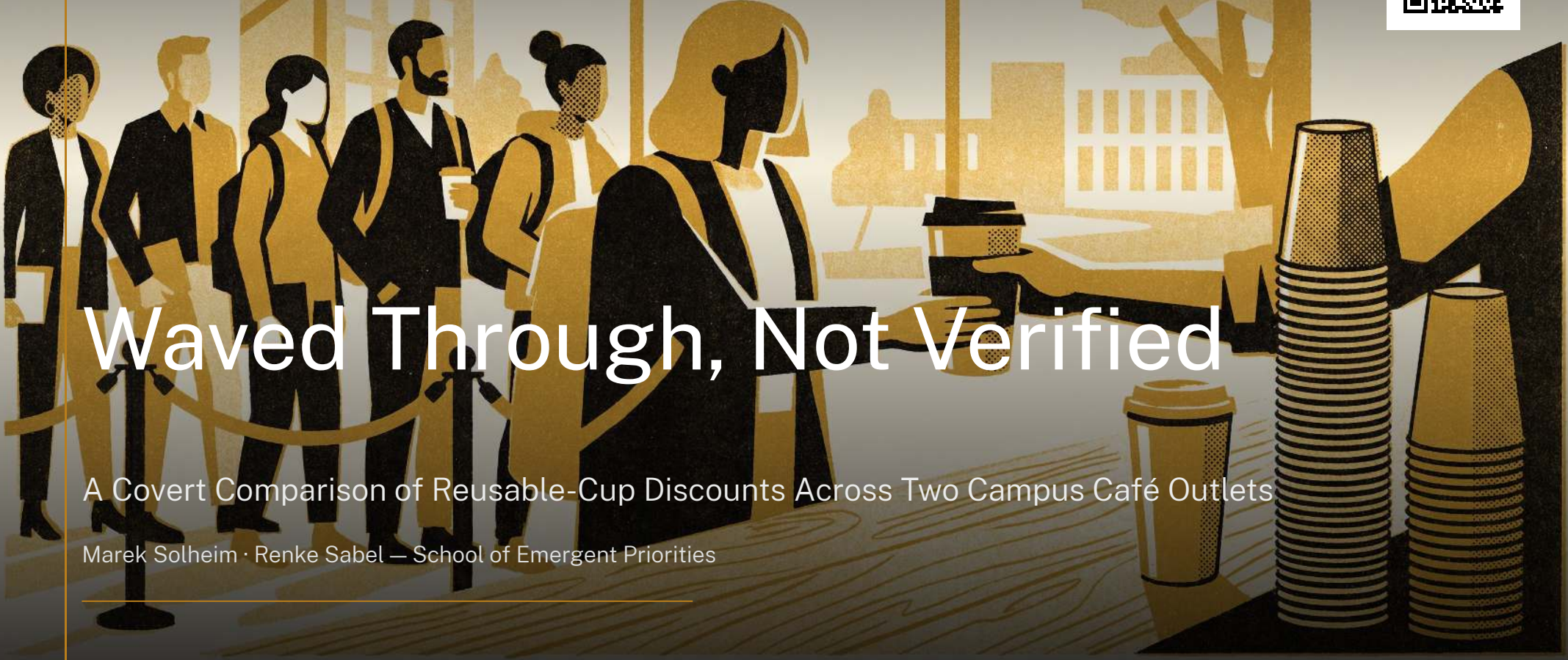




Waved Through, Not Verified

A Covert Comparison of Reusable-Cup Discounts Across Two Campus Café Outlets

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Motivation

The café’s reusable-cup discount applies the moment a customer requests it; nothing at the till confirms a cup changed hands. The Sustainability Office cites the resulting redemption rate as falling disposable-cup use. Whether the figure still requires a cup is untested.

What we set out to test

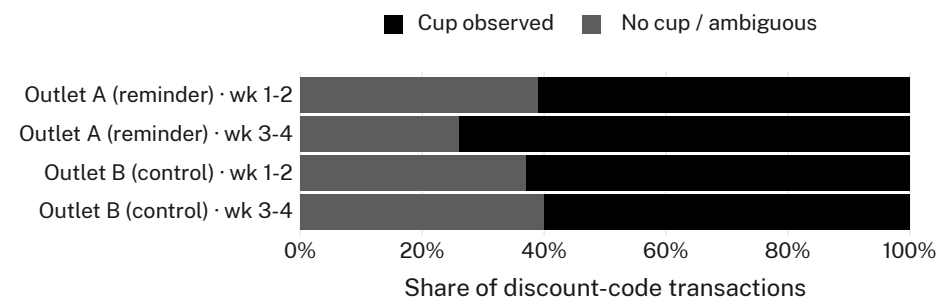
- Whether discount-code redemption tracks observed cup-carriage
- Whether an unannounced staff reminder shifts observed carriage, till behaviour, or both
- Whether the redemption figure still functions as a valid proxy for cup use

Study design

- 2 matched café outlets · covert point-of-sale observation · 4 weeks
- Independent observers logged cup-carriage, blind to till records
- Outlet A received an unannounced barista reminder at week 2; Outlet B continued as usual

Results

Discount-code redemption held at 90-94% throughout the four-week window, unmoved by outlet, week, or the reminder. Observed cup-carriage moved only at the reminded outlet, and only after the reminder.



Cup observed at the point of sale, as a share of discount-code transactions: 61% at Outlet A in the week of 9 February 2026, rising to 74% by 9 March following an unannounced reminder to baristas, against a steady 60-63% at unreminded Outlet B across the same four weeks.

What it means

The till code checks nothing; a barista’s habit does, and habits answer to a reminder in a way the redemption figure never does. The number the Sustainability Office reports moves with staff courtesy, not customer behaviour. Next: a term-long trial pairing the reminder with an unannounced spot-check, both outlets.

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Human ethics approval 2025/118; discount-code flags logged, no payment data retained; baristas debriefed after each observation window.